Word Policing Is Currently Broken

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Introduction: Word Policing's Current Injustice

[1]In this essay, I will argue that word policing is unjust when not context-sensitive and explicitly providing context —a process I term **'meaning molding'**—achieves the ethical goals of word policing over banning or replacing hateful words. To establish this argument, I will explain that words gain meaning purely from context, establish a model for conversation, define the practice and ends of word policing, examine its current state, and show a contemporary case of word policing that utilizes two very different tactics during a high-stakes situation. Afterwards using the conversation model, deontology, and consequentialism, I will argue that word policing in this contemporary case was unjust. I will use this injustice to uncover a framework for responsible communication and apply meaning molding as a solution to not only the case and this framework but to word policing as a whole.

[1] As you might see over the course of this essay, English is fundamentally flawed. Therefore, in order to better convey meaning, I will encode more meaning into my sentences through formatting and color.
Underline - this is critical to understand or key point of the sentence
Bold – this is a key word
Blue – this is a definition or reference to a definition
Additionally, I will include a definition reference so you don't have to flip to the definition or thesis if you forgot it's meaning

Explication: Establishing the Premise of Word Context and Policing

[2]Words are contextual symbols. Language is an acquired ability; humans do not possess innate speech at birth, but rather develop it through the interpretation of their environment. Humans use sounds to create symbols which in turn gain meaning through their associated environment or context. Word context may be any observable thing: anything that can be touched, seen, heard, tasted, or smelt (Antonucci & Alt, 2011). Word context may be any imaginable thing: any idea that can be determined from the personal environments or knowledge gained by others (Gandhi & Mukherji, 2023). This contradicts the belief that words have inherent meaning, because if humans have to learn language from scratch, then words are only understood through personal understanding and experience. Therefore, if meanings are personal, then the words cannot have an inherent meaning.

In English, these contextual symbols (words) are associated with multiple meanings that evolve over time and in different places. More formal meanings might be defined by a dictionary whereas less formal meanings reflect local, cultural usages, personal associations with the idea, and environmental clues. For instance, take a contemporary, vilified word: **Nazi**. One might define the word **Nazi** to mean "a member of a German fascist party controlling Germany from 1933 to 1945 under Adolf Hitler"; "one who espouses the beliefs and policies of the German Nazis" (Merriam-Webster, 2025); or the word **Nazi** could be defined by its current, less formal cultural use "A person who has a different opinion than you." (NotPieGuy, 2021); or "a person who you don't like" (anonym0u$e, 2023). It is not unusual for an English word to have multiple

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[2] Meaning molding: (p. 1)
explicitly providing context
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meanings, both formal and informal. In fact, 64% of the 9,000 most commonly used English words have more than one meaning (Ozturk, 2017). This means that in a given day, when the average 11,950 words are spoken (Tidwell et al., 2025), the permutations of potential meanings in a single day of conversation are effectively infinite, far exceeding the number of atoms in the observable universe. This mind-boggling figure is not even constant because people add to or take away meanings from words all the time. This concept is evident in the word **Nazi**, whose use in 100 years has dramatically changed from the 2025 to the 2021 to the 1945 definition to the 1933 definition.

[3]How can humans navigate such semantic complexity? The same way words were learned in the first place – context! By combining multiple contextual symbols (words), the speaker can reduce the number of correct understandings or meanings that any given word in the phrase can take (Akanya & Omachonu, 2019). Consider the phrase "I am reading a paragraph about **Nazis**" and if I add one word, it refines the meaning of the sentence "I am reading a paragraph about grammar **Nazis**". By adding one word, it refines the meaning. Learned symbol patterns can further refine these meanings - patterns like grammar and syntax structures such as adjectives and adverbs in prepositional phrases or argumentative structures for writing argumentative philosophy papers. However, because the receiver does not attribute the same meanings to the same context symbols, they may misunderstand the spoken phrase's exact or fundamental meaning. Altogether, this imperfect system where humans communicate meaning by stringing together contextual symbols will be called the **conversation model**.

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Word are contextual symbols, which evolve, have multiple meanings (p. 3-4)

[4]In practice, humans misuse their ability to communicate to convey hate, leading many to turn to **word policing** or the practice of controlling or correcting language to avoid hate speech or the connotation thereof. Like all pairs of contextual symbols, **hate speech** can be defined in a myriad of ways for a myriad of ends. But in this paper, hate speech will mean "speech that expresses hate or encourages violence towards a person or group based on something such as race, religion, sex, or sexual orientation" (Cambridge Dictionary, n. d.).

Generally, people who promote word policing often emphasize correcting or banning hateful words (Rosalie, 1991). Some institutions like APA provide guidelines on inclusive language (American Psychological Association, 2023). Similarly, Social Media giants like YouTube, Meta, and X actively regulate hate speech (Google, n.d.; Meta, n. d.; X, n.d). Government bodies like the European Union, China, Kenya, and many others punish hate speech with fines or up to 10 years in prison (European Union, 2007; People's Republic of China, n.d.; NATIONAL COHESION AND INTEGRATION COMMISSION, n.d.). These regulatory bodies' word policing represents major stakeholders in how we conduct ourselves and engage with others scientifically, socially, legally, and economically.

Hate speech is regulated for good reason too. Hate speech is unjust in at least two major schools of moral thought: Deontologically (as shown by Immanuel Kant) and Consequentialism (as shown by John Stuart Mill). Hate speech is immoral under Kantian deontological ethics, because of the Categorical Imperative. Kant believes that morals are not relative to the action's

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[4] Conversation Model: (p. 4)
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effect or circumstances. For conduct to be moral, it should be applicable to any circumstance. This principle formally is called **Kant's Categorical Imperative**, defined as follows: "Act only according to that maxim whereby you can at the same time will that it should become a universal law" (Kant, 2008, p. 11). In other words, before an action is taken, consider the action's intent, and see if that intent can be universalized. Consider the application of **Kant's Categorical Imperative** to hate speech:

[5]**Proposition**:

> I will promote hatred and encourage the violent treatment of any person or group whose identity traits (e.g., race, religion, etc.) I despise.

Contradiction:

> If I will a universal law that permits violating the dignity of others based on identity, I am willing that a law that could validly be used to violate my own dignity, which contradicts my self-love/preservation.

Likewise, hate speech is immoral under Mill's Consequentialist ethics as discussed in *Utilitarianism* and *On Liberty.* However, Mill believes that morals are based on the action's effect or circumstances, relative to happiness, a universal human value and desire as shown by the **Greatest Happiness Principle**: "…that actions are right in proportion as they tend to

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promote happiness, wrong as they tend to produce the reverse of happiness" (Mill & Mulgan, 2020, p. 186), and he goes on to argue that moral actors should consider everyone's effected happiness. Consider the application of **Mill's Greatest Happiness Principle** to hate speech. Hate speech's entire purpose is to produce the reverse of happiness. So as long as one successfully incites violence and hate, it is immoral, assuming being hated, hurt, or killed will produce unhappiness. Additionally, Mill does argue against hate speech in *On Liberty* that speech used to encourage a "mischievous act" or to "do harm to others" should be restricted, citing: "An opinion that corn-dealers are starvers of the poor, or that private property is robbery… may justly incur punishment when delivered orally to an excited mob assembled before the house of a corn-dealer" (2011, p. 104). The above speaker is certainly conveying hate speech by inciting the mob crowd to anger and hate toward the corn dealer.

[6]What is the 2006 Paul Dawson and Keysean Chavers Incident?

With these principles: "words are contextual", "conversation model", and "word policing: the practice, end, and why it exists" now established, one can introduce a modern miscommunication of a word – the Dawson/Chavers Incident, but before that I must declare my

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intent and contextualize why I **word police** the story's slur and why this story is used. I am trying to establish through the current system of contextless **word policing** that it is wrong to contextless **word police**. This is done so the reader can understand my position before they are offended by the word. So, instead using the word Dawson used, this paper will use the term "slur" instead because the word slur functions as a reference to a huge group of potential hateful words. This is to ensure that the direct word cannot be fully understood. If you take offense to hate speech, do not investigate the sources to understand the intended meaning of the word "slur". The word in and of itself will never be communicated because it is completely unnecessary because this paper is not focused on slurs, but about word policing. Additionally, this story is chosen because reflects an awful miscommunication of a word which has had a terrible history and has evolved dramatically from its original use; the arguments surrounding word policing; and a practical use of the proposed "meaning molding" through the argument's extreme logical application.

[7]At a high school in Louisville, Kentucky, an English teacher with a 20-year career, Paul Dawson, told Keysean Chavers to sit down using a slur, sparking a huge controversy in the wider

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community. Dawson thought the slur's use was acceptable because of its slang connotation, its frequent use by his students, its use by Chavers, and "to feel more comfortable with [the slur's ethnic targets[8]]", despite being the ethnic group who historically used the slur hatefully. On the other hand, Keysean Chavers, a Boy Scout, ROTC, honors student, and the slur's historical ethic target, thought Dawson's use was completely inappropriate and called for his resignation and for a complete district-wide ban (at that time, the punishment was determined on a case-by-case basis). The Dawson/Chavers Incident gained notoriety when the story was aired on a local news station, WHAS-11, by Renee Murphy, a newswoman who also was a historical target of the slur. Before airing the clip of Dawson and Chavers, she presented the new station's intent behind airing the full uncensored story, arguing Dawson's intent and slur's definition was important to understand what happened **(**Amara, n.d.). A month later, Mr. Dawson was consequentially permanently reassigned to administrative work despite pro-Dawson student protests and walkouts (Marshall, 2006). Twelve years later, Mrs. Murphy left WHAS-11 for the Parent Outreach for Jefferson County Public Schools (Williams, 2018). **[9]**

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[8] Censored because the word is not important. See news coverage for uncensored version.

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Argument: Contextless Word Policing is Unjust; Meaning Molding is the Answer

[10]Before establishing that word policing is unjust through intent versus interpretation, one must establish that the use alone is not the moral issue. Consider the reaction to Murphy's use of the slur versus Dawson's use of the slur. In Dawson's case, he said the slur, and he effectively lost his job a month later. In Murphy's case, she repeatedly referenced the slur, but she retired 12 years later after a successful journalistic career. Some might point out that Murphy used the slur's reference while Dawson used the slur itself, suggesting that reference to the slur doesn't carry the same weight as using of the slur itself. But consider this instance through the lens of the **conversation model**:

Murphy's reference to the slur:

Word	Possible Meanings	How
Slur Reference	That it is a reference + referenced slur	By splitting up the word
Slur Reference	Non-hateful intention + slur	By the fact that it is a reference, not the word, it signals to the listener that the speaker understands the word is taboo.

Dawson's use of the slur:

Word	Possible Meanings	How

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Slur	Slur	By transitive property
Slur	Non-hateful intention + slur	By assuming Dawson was truthful and did not intend to cause offense, be hateful or incite violence toward Chavers

Therefore, Dawson's and Murphy's usages are logically equivalent in their semantic meaning. If it is equivalent in use, why does it garner such different consequences?

[11]English's imperfect communication system failed in the case of Dawson and Chavers, which is huge problem. Dawson used the slur, which he deduced from his contextual view to be appropriate, intending to tell Chavers to sit down. Chavers heard the slur and interpreted it in his context as speech that expresses hate. Chavers' response successfully controlled Dawson's words and set in motion a chain of events that led to Dawson's temporary suspension, re-education, job reassignment, and relocation. While **hate speech** is unjust under both Kantian and Millian ethics, using a Deontology argument, punishing Dawson was unjust because Dawson did not intend to cause hate; using a Consequentialist argument, the use of the slur negatively affected Chavers, Dawson's career, and the slur's historical targets who listened to the WHAS-11 broadcast at the time and ever since. But should it have?

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While Dawson verbalized the slur, if one assumes that Dawson was the type of person who would inspire protests and walkouts when the school district threatened to remove him, using the **conversation model**, Chavers should have used his knowledge of Dawson's character to better understand and guide his (Chaver's) understanding of the slur. Either Chavers should not have concluded that Dawson's use of the slur reflected the slur's full unbridled historical meaning or Chavers should have considered whether he may have misunderstood Dawson's intended meaning and asked Dawson to clarify or explain its intended meaning. Furthermore, those who did not know Dawson personally and watched the WHAS-11 broadcast heard Dawson's explanation and his intended definition of the word. Dawson's explanation clarified the intended meaning in that instance. How then can one take offense to their misunderstanding if they know the context and meaning isn't attempting to encourage violence or express hate? Granted, the phrase Dawson used created many unnecessary and hateful permutations, but the ill effect should have stopped when he explained his intent and his understanding of the words he spoke to Chavers.[12]

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[13]Now that the injustice of word policing has been established in the Chavers/Dawson Incident, two principles for controlling or correcting hateful words can be established: the speaker's responsibility and the listener's responsibility in communication. The speaker's responsibility is to convey their meaning, so in order to do that, by the **conversation model**, they must use word symbols that would allow their meaning to be understood by the audience. To apply **Kant's Categorical Imperative**, consider the opposite:

Proposition:

When I communicate, I will intentionally use language and symbols that prevent my audience from understanding the fundamental meaning I intend to convey.

Contradiction:

Because everyone at all times will not understand your fundamental meaning, then there will be no point to communicate.

To apply this to Mr. Dawson, he shouldn't have used language that his audience so easily misinterpreted as hateful. Likewise, there is a responsibility of the listener to attempt to understand the speaker's meaning. Here again is a **Kantian Categorical Imperative** Proof:

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Proposition:

When I listen to someone communicate, I will not try to comprehend the fundamental, intended meaning of the conversation.

Contradiction:

Because everyone at all times will not try to comprehend the fundamental meaning communicated, then there will be no point to communicate.

[14]Therefore, if the listener does not understand the phrase's intended meaning, then they have a duty to figure it out before criticizing or assigning fault or punishment. This is not a new concept. People already ask someone to repeat/clarify phrases that do not align with their understanding of the conversation or person. To apply this to Chavers and the WHAS-11 audience, they disregarded the intended meaning of the slur as explained by Dawson, but accepted the intended meaning of the slur as explained by Murphy. What is the basis for punishing one, but not the other? Where is the moral high ground? We come to understand the proverb: communication is a two way street.

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[15]To apply these principles back to real life within this framework, how can people communicate and understand each other? The same way conversations occur in the first place – by providing context or **meaning molding**. In the WHAS-11 coverage, even though Renee Murphy conveyed the same set of meanings as Mr. Dawson through their references to slurs and showing "hateful" clips, people watching could understand the reporters' intended meaning, fulfilling the speaker's responsibility. She explicitly "meaning molded", communicating their intent using words the audience understands: "Story contains graphic language", "language in this story is strong and may offend some people"; "not just about the [slur[16]] it's also about the pronunciation, we've decided to leave it in the story for you to decide" (Amara, n.d.). In other words, Murphy "wrapped" or "flagged" the potentially dangerous language with enough **context** that the recipient could fully understand the meaning of the use of the slur in the sentences and avoid miscommunication.

Now that the injustice of ignoring context in conversation is established, we will show the misapplication of banning or replacing words in **word policing**, and the applicability of

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[16] Censored because the word is not important. See news coverage for uncensored version.

meaning molding. Banning certain symbols does not work because it does not ban its meaning. Since the association usefulness hasn't changed, the meaning is just assigned to a new previously-mundane-or-polite contextual symbol (see Euphemism Treadmill) (Pinker, 1994). Furthermore, banning presupposes that the meaning will never change, and the meaning will always be hateful, which can be totally rejected by the conversation model and by the reclamation movement (Fasehun, 2017). Humans have the power to attribute whatever meaning to words they may desire. And what better way to reclaim or reconquer hateful words than to expressly declare intent or contextualize its new use, and using the speaker's context to determine that they are not being hateful. [17]

Concluding Remarks

In this paper, I have established through two major schools of ethical thought, Consequentialism and Deontology, that word policing is unjust when it ignores context, even when applied to the Dawson/Chavers Incident. I have rejected the idea that banning or replacing words is a solution to **word policing**, rather, I have given deontological / Kantian / logical proof to the responsibly of speakers to speak clearly to their respective audience, and the listener's

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responsibility to try to understand the fundamental ideas being communicated. I gave a practical example of this ethical communication and meaning molding using the Dawson/Chavers Incident through Renee Murphy's referential use of "America's ugliest word" (Bailey & Walker, 2006) and her avoidance of ethical harm. By arguing that context should dictate word policing, I sincerely hope that cases like the Dawson/Chaver Incident can be avoided in the future. Dawson's 20-year teaching career was ruined - all those hours preparing and executing lesson plans, all those late nights grading papers, all those people he helped - all completed destroyed in one moment by a meaning Dawson did not use. I hope Dawson's loss serves as a stepping stone toward humanity's greater happiness. I hope that this paper helps promote greater understanding between people everywhere.[18]

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